down'. As he took their leave, Rajiv Gandhi added 'with a twinkle in his eye': 'You have got good copy.'[27]

To the large number of Congressmen gathered on the tarmac, the impact of this off-the-cuff announcement was 'to put it mildly, as shocking as it was dramatic'. Gandhi had no doubt expected that the change of guard would be smooth. But Patil fought back, and publicly. He invited journalists and a Doordarshan TV crew to his house. He told them that, while he had been temporarily unwell, his faculties were intact and he would keep working as chief minister. Speaking to Doordarshan, Patil was 'more or less declaring war against his own party'. 'I was not asked to step down and I am not stepping down,' he said in his televised speech,[28] adding that the leadership issue 'did not arise when Gandhi had met him'.[29] This was now a full-blown constitutional crisis. With the chief minister remaining adamant, the Congress calling a legislators' meeting to elect a new leader and both sides claiming to have the required numbers, President R. Venkataraman declared President's Rule in the state on 10 October, after duly seeking advice from Governor Bhanu Pratap Singh.[30]

V.P. Singh was then serving as prime minister of a Janata Dal-led coalition government in Delhi. His party offered Patil unconditional support towards winning the floor test. Its state leader Jeevaraj Alva accused Rajiv Gandhi of a 'dictatorial attitude' that must be 'condemned by all those who still have some dignity irrespective of political affiliations'.[31] The airport sacking had become such a public spectacle that the prime minister now personally entered the debate, directly targeting Rajiv Gandhi. He released a statement saying, 'Despite its huge majority in the house, the Congress government had been destabilised by the party president, Mr Rajiv Gandhi.'[32] As *The Times of India* noted, 'under normal circumstances, Congress leaders should have been angry with the National Front and the governor. But it appears they were angrier with Mr Patil for bringing the situation to such a pass.' The 'coup' at the airport, the newspaper concluded, had 'boomeranged'.[33] In the event, Patil lost the battle. S. Bangarappa was elected as his